APRIL 2026
UM WORLDWIDE
FOR EXXONMOBIL
U.S. UPFRONTS ·

UM·WORLDWIDE

The *Agentic* Upfront.

How 2026 Changes How We Buy.

This is the first Upfront where agents buy alongside buyers. NBCU ran the first AI-agent-led PG deal in Q1. The Trade Desk shipped Koa. Amazon is leading with agentic creative. Everything else — streaming scale, outcomes-based measurement, the calendar itself — is a *response* to that shift.

ISSUE	EDITOR	CONTRIBUTORS	PREPARED FOR
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— 2026 UPFRONTS PREVIEW

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THE THESIS

The 2026 Upfront isn't a negotiation between buyers and sellers. It's the first three-way negotiation — buyers, sellers, and *agents*. From allocation to optimization. From commitments to *frameworks*. From decks on stage to protocols in production.

THE AGENTIC UPFRONT · THE HEADLINE STORY OF 2026

02

Agents Enter The Room.

For the first time, a real AI-agent-led deal has been bought, run, and measured in U.S. television. Every major publisher is reformatting their 2026 pitch around what that means. This is no longer a capability to watch — it's the operating layer the rest of the upfront is being rebuilt on top of.

> *"Agentic buying will not replace the need for upfront commitments, nor the human relationships they rely on. It will be similar to what happened when programmatic became a way to transact. It didn't make the upfronts less relevant — it made them more relevant."*
>
> SENIOR SELLER, AD AGE BUYER/SELLER ROUNDTABLE

> *"2026 marks the beginning of the end for manual programmatic buying."*
>
> EMARKETER · 2026 OUTLOOK

> *"We expect ~25% of online spending to flow through AI shopping agents by 2030."*
>
> MORGAN STANLEY RESEARCH

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENED — THE EVIDENCE

APR 21, 2026	**The Trade Desk · Koa Agents** Biggest product launch in TTD's history. Agentic buying layer sitting on top of the platform. Alpha with Stagwell. Positioned as the beginning of the end of manual programmatic.	PRODUCT LAUNCH
Q1 2026	**NBCU × FreeWheel · First AI-Agent-Led PG Deal** First major publisher-side campaign bought entirely via agent negotiation — live sports, linear + streaming. Mark Marshall called it a redefinition of how TV inventory is bought and sold.	INDUSTRY FIRST
UPFRONT 2026	**Amazon · Agentic Campaign + Creative Tools** Central pitch now foregrounds agentic AI for media and creative, plus 300M monthly ad-supported audience and 90% U.S. household authenticated reach.	PLATFORM
DEC 2025	**AdCP · First Standardized Test Buys** Ad Context Protocol emerging as the universal interoperability standard. Magnite, MiQ, and Scope3 completed early test buys in December 2025.	STANDARD
2026 UPFRONT	**EDO · ChatEDO Opens to All Agencies** Agentic AI interface to EDO's TV ad performance database. Free access for all ad agencies through the 2026 upfront cycle.	TOOLS

THE EMERGING AGENTIC STACK

INTERFACE WHERE BUYERS TALK TO THE SYSTEM	Instead of logging into a DSP and setting parameters manually, planners increasingly type or speak their goals into a chat-style interface. The interface translates intent into the technical steps. IN MARKET · CHATEDO (EDO'S CONVERSATIONAL TV-ATTRIBUTION TOOL) · COPILOT-STYLE BUYER DASHBOARDS BEING ROLLED OUT BY AMAZON, TTD, YAHOO · AGENT-AWARE CRMS AT HOLDING COMPANIES
AGENT THE AI THAT ACTUALLY DOES THE BUYING	An autonomous system that reads a brief, negotiates inventory, executes the buy, and optimizes mid-flight — doing in minutes what a team of planners previously did over days. IN MARKET · THE TRADE DESK'S KOA (LIVE THIS YEAR) · AMAZON'S DSP AGENTS · NBCU'S FREEWHEEL AGENT (RAN THE FIRST AGENTIC TV DEAL IN NFL PLAYOFFS, Q1 2026)
PROTOCOL THE SHARED LANGUAGE BETWEEN AGENTS	For an agent on the buy side to negotiate with an agent on the sell side, they need a common vocabulary for audiences, inventory and outcomes. AdCP is the emerging open standard trying to become that universal layer — think 'HTTP for ad agents.' IN MARKET · ADCP (AD CONTEXT PROTOCOL) — EMERGING UNIVERSAL STANDARD BACKED BY MAGNITE, MIQ, SCOPE3 AND OTHERS
MEASUREMENT HOW THE AGENT KNOWS IT WORKED	Agents can only optimize toward outcomes they can see. Outcome measurement (store visits, sales lift, brand search) and clean rooms (privacy-safe data matching) are what let the agent close the loop instead of optimizing to impressions. IN MARKET · ISPOT OUTCOMES · VIDEOAMP · DATA CLEAN ROOMS (SNOWFLAKE, LIVERAMP, HABU) · ACR-BASED CROSS-SCREEN MEASUREMENT (VIZIO, SAMSUNG ADS)
INVENTORY WHAT THE AGENT IS ACTUALLY BUYING	The pool of ad inventory that has been unlocked for agentic access. In 2026, upfront deals are still negotiated by humans, but executed and optimized by agents — and scatter inventory is increasingly priced and traded agent-to-agent throughout the year. IN MARKET · UPFRONT COMMITMENTS NEGOTIATED BY HUMANS, EXECUTED BY AGENTS · SCATTER INVENTORY PRICED DYNAMICALLY YEAR-ROUND · STREAMING CTV FIRST, LINEAR NEXT

LAYERS OF THE 2026 BUYING STACK · READ TOP-DOWN

THE UPFRONT WEEK MAP · DATES, VENUES, SIGNALS

03

The Calendar Is The Story.

Here's who shows up when, where, and what to read between the venues.

CBS PRE-WEEK

Apr 15
WED · 2026

CBS (Paramount/Skydance)

UPFRONT
Carnegie Hall · 4:00 PM

CBS has pulled out of traditional upfront week entirely. First major publisher to break rank.

SUPER MONDAY · 3 PRESENTATIONS

May 11
MON · 2026

NBCUniversal

UPFRONT · "SUPER MONDAY"
Radio City Music Hall · 10:30 AM · 100th anniversary

First full season of the new NBA rights deal, Super Bowl LXI runway, Peacock's agentic PG framework — 'the most-loaded year in company history.'

May 11
MON · 2026

Fox Corporation

UPFRONT · SUPER MONDAY
New York City Center · 4:00 PM

Live-first positioning. Tubi + Fox One + news/sports trifecta.

May 11 Amazon
MON · 2026
UPFRONT · SUPER MONDAY
Beacon Theatre · 6:30 PM
Agentic AI tools, 300M monthly ad-supported audience, 90% U.S. household authenticated reach.

UPFRONT WEEK · 3 PRESENTATIONS

May 12 Telemundo
TUE · 2026
UPFRONT · CLIENT EXPERIENCE
Tribeca Performing Arts Center
Live-first multicultural play. Liga MX, Copa Oro, Spanish-language Super Bowl LXI simulcast.

May 12 Disney
TUE · 2026
UPFRONT
North Javits Center · 4:00 PM
ESPN flagship streamer + D+/Hulu/Max bundle – the deepest sports portfolio.

May 13 Discovery Global (WBD)
WED · 2026
UPFRONT
MSG Theater · 10:00 AM
Newly renamed, selling WBD inventory too. "One-stop shop" positioning.

04

THE MARKET · SOFTER MARKET, SMARTER DOLLARS

Moderated Spend, Sharper Allocation.

Streaming grew faster than anyone projected (+18.9% vs. +14% forecast). Linear fell less severely than projected in 2025 (–4.5% vs. –7%) – but the decline is accelerating again in 2026, and cross-platform parity is just about arithmetic at this point.

+18.9%
Streaming TV ad sales growth
2025 actual · beat 2024's +14% forecast
SOURCE · MAGNA

–4.5%
Linear ad sales decline in 2025
Projected to accelerate to –5.9% in 2026
SOURCE · MAGNA

~75%
Of national TV ad dollars now flow through upfronts
Up from 60% five years ago
SOURCE · MAGNA

$46B
National cross-platform TV spend, holding steady
Streaming growth offsets linear decline
SOURCE · MAGNA

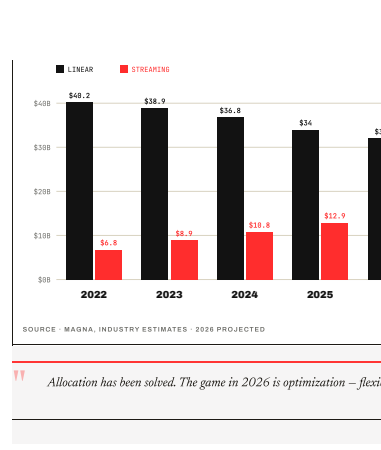
THE GAP IS CLOSING
U.S. ad sales, billions – streaming vs. linear national TV, 2022–2026(E)

WHAT TO WATCH

Cross-platform TV spend is holding steady at roughly **$46B** – but the composition is changing every quarter. Streaming is absorbing every dollar linear sheds, and then some.

Upfront concentration is a quieter story with bigger implications. **~75% of national TV ad dollars now move through upfront deals**, up from 60% five years ago. The upfront isn't shrinking – it's becoming the only room that matters. What's shrinking is scatter's ability to correct mistakes made in May.

That's why buyer posture matters more than ever: advertisers are holding dollars longer, demanding more flexibility, and pressuring CPMs down. Q3 2025 was brutal for linear – **English broadcast down –10.5%.**



SOURCE · MAGNA, INDUSTRY ESTIMATES · 2026 PROJECTED

> *Allocation has been solved. The game in 2026 is optimization — flexibility, measurement, and platform power.*

CTV & STREAMING · THE NEW CENTER OF GRAVITY

05

Streaming Is Now How You Reach Everyone.

84% of U.S. households. 45% of A18–49 viewing. Netflix and Amazon alone now account for roughly 30% of streaming ad sales — and the rest of the landscape consolidates around them.

84%

Of U.S. households subscribed to at least one major streaming service by end of 2024

SOURCE · MAGNA

10.9

Streaming services per consumer per month in 2025

Up from 8 in 2024

SOURCE · MAGNA

45%

Of ad-supported video viewing now takes place on CTV (A18–49)

SOURCE · MAGNA

62%

Of consumers willing to watch ads in exchange for lower costs

Up from 58% in 2024

SOURCE · KANTAR

44%

Of consumers subscribe to at least one streaming bundle

Disney+/Hulu/Max, etc.

SOURCE · MAGNA

~30%

Of streaming ad sales now controlled by Netflix + Amazon alone

Netflix doubled upfront commitments YoY

SOURCE · INDUSTRY

THREE DYNAMICS · ONE DIRECTION

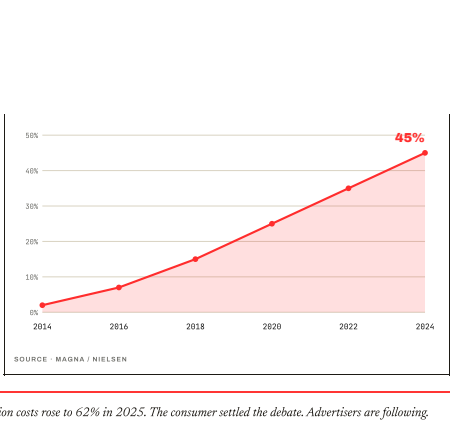
Expansion of ad-supported tiers. 78% of Peacock viewers and 73% of Prime Video viewers are now on ad tiers. The SVOD-AVOD pricing gap keeps widening, pushing consumers into ad-supported environments with 3–8 min/hour ad loads — a tolerable exchange at a substantial discount.

Platform consolidation. Netflix doubled its upfront commitments. Together with Amazon, it controls ~30% of streaming ad dollars. The rest of the market is either bundling (Disney+/Hulu/Max) or being acquired (HBO into Paramount).

STREAMING'S SHARE OF A18–49 VIDEO TIME

2% in 2014 → 45% in 2024. The curve didn't flatten.

Premiumization. CTV environments are selling outcome measurement, contextual targeting, and sports rights – not just reach. The case for a CTV CPM premium is now earned, not assumed.



SOURCE · MAGNA / NIELSEN

> *Willingness to watch ads in exchange for lower subscription costs rose to 62% in 2025. The consumer settled the debate. Advertisers are following.*
>
> — KANTAR · 2025 MEDIA REACTIONS

LINEAR REALITY · NOT DEAD — COMPRESSED

06

Linear's Role Is Real. It's Just Smaller.

Weekly consumption fell from 31+ hours in 2008–09 to 6.5 hours in 2024. Median broadcast primetime viewer is over 65. Cable's weekly reach dropped from 54% to 30% in five years. Linear isn't disappearing – it's being compressed into specific use cases.

6.5
Hours/week of linear TV in 2024
Peaked at 31+ hrs/week in 2008–09
SOURCE · MAGNA

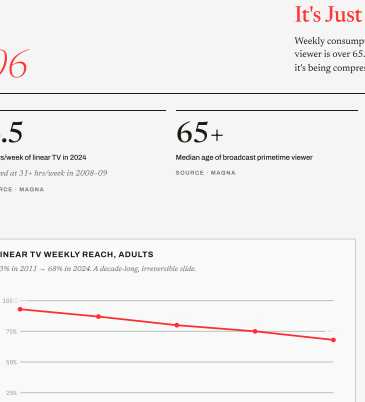
65+
Median age of broadcast primetime viewer
SOURCE · MAGNA

7%
Of adults say nearly all their TV is through traditional channels
SOURCE · KANTAR

13%
Linear's share of total U.S. ad spend in 2024
Surpassed by digital back in 2016
SOURCE · MAGNA

LINEAR TV WEEKLY REACH, ADULTS

93% in 2011 → 68% in 2024. A decade-long, irreversible slide.



SOURCE · MAGNA

WHAT LINEAR STILL DOES

Live events. Sports, breaking news, awards, major cultural moments. Linear remains the default when simultaneity matters.

Older demos at scale. The 55+ audience is still in linear's gravitational well. For advertisers who need that audience, linear remains the single most efficient buy.

Categorical anchors. Finance (12%), Pharma (12%), and Personal Care (11%) together represent 35% of linear spend. These categories are structurally slow to migrate – a measurement floor networks will defend aggressively.

Cord-cutting arithmetic. Traditional MVPD households are shedding 5–6M per year. Virtual MVPDs aren't absorbing the loss fast enough. The numbers don't reverse.

> *We need to defend our linear TV. How? By focusing on live TV. If you are live, you are on Telemundo.*
>
> — LUIS FERNANDEZ · CHAIRMAN, NBCUNIVERSAL TELEMUNDO ENTERPRISES

07

SUPER BOWL LXI.

NBC/Peacock · February 2027. The single biggest buy in the Q4 '26–Q3 '27 window. First Super Bowl sold under NBCU's agentic PG framework — expect a measurement-linked package, not just a 30-second spot.

CATEGORIES WE EXPECT TO LEAD IN

SPORTS · THE LAST DRIVER OF SCALE

Live Sports Is The Final Mass Medium.

Q4 '26 through Q3 '27 is the first full season under the new NBA rights split and the runway to Super Bowl LXI on NBC. Every other category is fragmenting; sports is the only place simultaneous mass audiences still assemble. In 2026, that scarcity gets priced — hard.

FINANCE / CRYPTO / BETTING	Now ~20% of sports spend. Expect record Super Bowl category volume; FanDuel/DraftKings/Robinhood holding flights.
AUTO / EV	First Super Bowl where Chinese EV entrants (BYD, others) are plausible buyers; domestic OEMs defend.
TECH / AI	The consumer-AI category (OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, Meta) has matured into a legitimate Super Bowl advertiser class.
ENERGY / MOBILITY	ExxonMobil's natural window — fuel efficiency + Mobil 1 stories land hardest with live-sports intent audiences.
STREAMING / ENTERTAINMENT	Peacock, Netflix, Prime, Max all using the game to seed Q1 '27 slate launches.

RIGHTS MOVES THAT DEFINE THE 2026 ROOM

LEAGUE	NOW HOME	IMPLICATION
NBA / WNBA – YEAR 1	NBC · Amazon Prime · Disney	First FULL season (Oct '26 – Jun '27) under the new 11-yr, $76B rights split. Defines the fall. Every network's pitch touches this.
WNBA – YEAR 2 OF NEW DEAL	Disney · NBC · Amazon	Caitlin Clark era at scale. Fastest-growing U.S. pro sports property; ratings still compounding YoY.
CFP NATIONAL CHAMPIONSHIP 2027	ESPN / ABC	Post-12-team expansion, second year under the new format — ratings floor is now permanently higher.
RYDER CUP 2027	NBC · Adare Manor, Ireland	Premium golf inventory in Sept '27, last major live event inside the buying window. European venue = global audience.
2027 NFL SEASON KICKOFF	CBS · Fox · NBC · ESPN · Amazon · Netflix	First year where Netflix Christmas Day games are a second-year proof point, not a novelty. Streaming share of NFL inventory keeps climbing.
MARCH MADNESS 2027	CBS · TNT · TruTV	Final year of the current CBS/Warner deal structure — negotiations for the next cycle begin in earnest during this upfront.

> *Sports inventory is the only thing in the 2026 market that's simultaneously scarce, scaling, and CPM-inelastic. That's not an adjective stack. That's a pricing memo.*
>
> — UM POINT OF VIEW

ECONOMICS · A MARKET DEFINED BY UNCERTAINTY

08

Caution, Optionality, and the Cost of Risk.

Ongoing instability in the Middle East — the U.S./Israel conflict with Iran, periodic closures of the Strait of Hormuz, and the downstream pressure on energy and shipping — is reshaping the CFO's view of 2026. Buyers aren't pulling back on TV. They're buying it differently: shorter commitments, more out-clauses, more scatter. Flexibility isn't a negotiation perk anymore. It's the product.

+14.2%

Digital ad spend growth forecast for 2026–27 as retail recovers

SOURCE · EMARKETER

Flex

Is the new premium. Advertisers are holding dollars longer and demanding more out-clauses.

GEOPOLITICAL PRESSURE	The U.S./Israel conflict with Iran and repeated closures of the Strait of Hormuz have kept energy and shipping costs volatile through 2025. CFOs are treating 2026 planning as a year of scenario planning, not a year of commitments.
BUYER POSTURE	Advertisers are holding dollars longer. Scatter is getting more attractive relative to upfront commitments — flexibility is the new premium.
CATEGORY EXPOSURE	The categories most sensitive to fuel costs, shipping and supply chains — Auto, Retail, CPG, Fuels — carry the most tonnage in TV. Intangibles (finance, entertainment, travel) remain relatively insulated.
RECOVERY SIGNAL	Digital ad spend is still forecast to accelerate +14.2% into 2026–27 as retail stabilizes — but the upside is back-weighted, which pushes more dollars into scatter and later quarters.

> *The buyers most exposed to geopolitical shocks — Auto, Retail, CPG, Fuels — also carry the most tonnage in TV. In that environment, the most valuable thing a network can sell isn't reach. It's out-clauses, scatter rollover, and third-party outcome verification.*
>
> — UM POINT OF VIEW

REGULATION & M&A · CONSOLIDATION HAS A GREEN LIGHT

09

The Market Is Being Rebuilt.

The FCC has signalled it will grant ownership-cap waivers. Megadeals are the new normal. And the CCPA/CPRA amendments that became enforceable on January 1, 2026 — the start of the new compliance year — reshape what data networks can actually package and sell.

M&A WAVE	Paramount-Skydance closed. Paramount acquisition of HBO in motion. PwC calls the environment 'headline-grabbing megadeals' — consolidation has shifted from defense to offense.
FCC POSTURE	Notably flexible. Nexstar now exceeds the 39% national cap, reaching 54.5% of U.S. TV households. Waivers signal recognition of digital competition.

PRIVACY PATCHWORK	Nearly 20 states now have comprehensive privacy laws. CCPA/CPRA amendments effective Jan 1, 2026 require risk assessments, audits, tightened consumer notifications, and ADM controls.
CLEAN-ROOM ACCELERATION	Data privacy constraints are a tailwind for clean-room adoption — the one place networks and advertisers can measure without violating a patchwork of state rules.

54.5%

Of U.S. TV households now reached by Nexstar — above the 39% cap, via FCC waiver.

~20

States with comprehensive privacy statutes. Media companies now navigate a patchwork.

JAN 1
2026

CCPA/CPRA amendments take effect — formal risk assessments, audits, ADM controls.

PWC · US DEALS 2026 OUTLOOK

Media and telecom transaction volume and value have accelerated over the past six months — characterized by headline-grabbing megadeals, increased consolidation within streaming, and a pronounced shift toward profitability and scale.

10

NETWORK SCOREBOARD · ELEVEN PLAYERS, FIVE AXES

Who Shows Up With What.

A supporting view, not a verdict. Five axes that together describe how each publisher is positioned to negotiate in the 2026 Upfronts. Click a column to sort.

NETWORK	AI / MEASUREMENT	SPORTS LEVERAGE	STREAMING SCALE	AUDIENCE YOUTH	FLEXIBILITY	TAGS
NBCUNIVERSAL	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●○	●●●○○	●●●●○	PEACOCK NBA YEAR 1
DISNEY	●●●●○	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●○	●●●●○	ESPN FLAGSHIP HULU/D+
AMAZON	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●○	●●●●○	PRIME VIDEO AGENTIC
FOX CORPORATION	●●●○○	●●●●●	●●●○○	●●●●○	●●●●●	TUBI NFL
DISCOVERY GLOBAL (WBD)	●●●●○	●●○○○	●●●●○	●●●○○	●●●●○	MAX HBO
PARAMOUNT / CBS	●●●●○	●●●●○	●●●●○	●●●○○	●●●●●	PARAMOUNT+ UFC
NETFLIX	●●●●○	●●●○○	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●○○	AVOD LIVE
YOUTUBE	●●●●●	●●●●○	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●○	CTV #1 SHORTS
ROKU	●●●●○	●●○○○	●●●●●	●●●○○	●●●●●	OS SCALE ROKU CHANNEL
TELEMUNDO	●●●○○	●●●●●	●●○○○	●●●●○	●●●●○	LIGA MX LIVE

APPLE TV+	●●●○○	●●●●○	●●●○○	●●●○○	●●●○○	MLS F1

SCORING · 1 = EMERGING, 5 = CATEGORY-DEFINING · UM ASSESSMENT

NETWORK DEEP-DIVES · ELEVEN ROOMS, ELEVEN PITCHES

What Each Network Walks In Selling.

11

Ordered chronologically by Upfront date. Each profile focuses on the pitch the network is bringing – the scarcity they're pricing against, the measurement story they're telling, and what to watch for in the room.

PUBLISHER · 01

NBCUniversal

"The most-loaded year in company history."

UPFRONT:
MON · MAY 11, 2026 · 10:30 AM · RADIO CITY MUSIC HALL (100TH ANNIVERSARY)

PEACOCK
NBA YEAR 1
SUPER BOWL LXI
AGENTIC

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●●●
Sports Leverage	●●●●●
Streaming Scale	●●●●○
Audience Youth	●●●○○
Flexibility	●●●●○

NBCU walks into 2026 with the biggest single-company slate in the Q4 '26 – Q3 '27 window – Super Bowl LXI, the first full season of the new NBA rights split (100 national regular-season games + playoff volume on Peacock), and the first AI-agent-led programmatic guaranteed deal in U.S. television already bought and running. The product story has finally caught up with the content story.

HIGHLIGHTS

- First AI-agent-led PG deal with FreeWheel – live sports, linear + streaming; first campaign ran in NFL playoffs Q1 2026
- LIVE Total Impact: retargeting viewers exposed to live ads (+6.8× website visit lift in telecom beta)
- Performance Insights Hub: in-flight measurement dashboard, AI-powered contextual targeting in LIVE
- Super Bowl LXI (Feb 2027) · first Super Bowl sold under NBCU's full agentic framework
- NBA Year 1 of new 11-year package – 100 regular-season games + playoff lineup on Peacock
- Peacock Arrival Ads + 280M+ combined reach across the full portfolio
- Versant spinoff (USA, E!, Syfy, Oxygen, Golf, CNBC, MS NOW) separated end of 2025 – still sold through NBCU upfront. Bravo stays.

WATCH FOR

The FreeWheel agentic deal isn't a pitch – it's already run. That makes NBCU the most credible agentic-AI story in the room.

PUBLISHER · 02

Disney

"Flagship ESPN streamer now defines the portfolio."

UPFRONT:
TUE · MAY 12, 2026 · 4:00 PM · NORTH JAVITS CENTER

ESPN FLAGSHIP
HULU/D+
NFL

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●●○
Sports Leverage	●●●●●
Streaming Scale	●●●●●
Audience Youth	●●●●○
Flexibility	●●●●○

Global Ads President Rita Ferro is positioning Disney as the flexibility-first partner for brands navigating uncertainty. The ESPN flagship streamer launch has quietly become the most consequential product ship in the market – combining live sports, betting, fantasy, and social into a single logged-in surface.

HIGHLIGHTS

- ESPN flagship streaming service now in-market – combines live sports, betting, fantasy, social
- Disney+/Hulu/Max bundle has reshaped subscriber economics (44% of consumers subscribe to at least one bundle)
- NFL, NBA, WNBA, College Football, F1 – the deepest sports rights portfolio

WATCH FOR

Watch for how ESPN prices inventory that's both linear and streaming-native. This is the pricing precedent other networks will follow.

PUBLISHER · 03

Amazon

"Agentic, first-party, unavoidable."

Amazon is the only player in the room with a first-party retail signal graph AND premium streaming inventory AND live sports AND a major agentic-AI story. Expect the 2026 pitch to center on closed-loop measurement and agentic campaign/creative tools – a combination other networks can only approximate through partner clean rooms.

UPFRONT:
MON · MAY 11, 2026 · 8:30 PM · BEACON THEATRE

PRIME VIDEO
AGENTIC
NBA
RETAIL

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●●●
Sports Leverage	●●●●●
Streaming Scale	●●●●●
Audience Youth	●●●●○
Flexibility	●●●●○

HIGHLIGHTS

- 300M monthly ad-supported viewers globally; 90% U.S. household authenticated reach via the Amazon graph
- Agentic AI campaign and creative tools positioned as a central message for 2026
- NBA, NASCAR, Thursday Night Football live rights anchoring the pitch
- X-Ray 'shop the show' + interactive ad formats scaling
- Prime Video ads expanding to 5 new international markets in 2025–26

WATCH FOR

The retail-media + CTV + agentic-AI flywheel is the hardest moat to replicate in TV advertising. Everyone else is assembling partnerships to approximate what Amazon owns.

PUBLISHER · 04

Fox Corporation

"Live-first, news-strong, Tubi-powered."

UPFRONT:
MON · MAY 11, 2026 · 4:00 PM · NEW YORK CITY CENTER

TUBI
NFL
NEWS
FOX ONE

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●○○
Sports Leverage	●●●●●
Streaming Scale	●●●○○
Audience Youth	●●●●○
Flexibility	●●●●●

Chief of Ad Sales Jeff Collins is coming in off a strong 2024–25 post-election audience acceleration. Tubi has quietly become one of the most important AVOD stories in the market — approaching 100M MAUs with a markedly younger, more multicultural audience than Fox's core.

HIGHLIGHTS

- Tubi ≈100M monthly active users — 50%+ Gen Z/Millennial, ~50% multicultural, 77% cord-cutters
- Fox One streaming service — broader sports/news/entertainment package launched late 2025
- Tubi NewFront Mar 24, 2026 kicks off the entire upfront season
- News, sports, live — the trifecta most resilient to measurement disruption

WATCH FOR

Tubi's audience profile makes Fox the quietest youth reach play in the broadcast set.

PUBLISHER · 05

Discovery Global (WBD)

"One-stop shop. Prestige + portfolio."

UPFRONT:
WED · MAY 13, 2026 · 10:00 AM · MSG THEATER

MAX
HBO
CLEAN ROOMS
ONE-STOP

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●●○
Sports Leverage	●●○○○
Streaming Scale	●●●●○
Audience Youth	●●●○○
Flexibility	●●●●○

Formally renamed Discovery Global in the 2025 restructuring, the company is now selling all WBD inventory — and pitching itself as a "one-stop shop" for premium scripted, lifestyle, and documentary at scale. The NBA loss to Amazon/NBCU hurt, but Max has become a legitimate prestige destination and the clean-room story is genuinely differentiated.

HIGHLIGHTS

- Rebranded Discovery Global – unified sell across Max, HBO, Discovery, TNT, TBS, CNN
- Max prestige slate: White Lotus (6.2M finale), The Pitt, Hacks, The Last of Us
- Data clean-room expansion with holding cos, Snowflake, VideoAmp
- HBO transaction with Paramount in motion – likely to reshape 2026 negotiations mid-year
- Sports storytelling rebuilding around college, Bleacher, and live events post-NBA

WATCH FOR

If the clean-room story lands, Discovery Global redefines how prestige inventory gets measured. If HBO moves to Paramount, this pitch changes fast.

PUBLISHER · 06

Paramount / CBS

"Skydance era · out of upfront week."

UPFRONT:
WED · APRIL 15, 2026 · 4:00 PM · CARNEGIE HALL (NOT UPFRONT WEEK)

PARAMOUNT+ UFC SKYDANCE

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●●○
Sports Leverage	●●●●○
Streaming Scale	●●●●○
Audience Youth	●●●○○
Flexibility	●●●●●

The Paramount-Skydance merger has closed, and CBS has formally pulled out of traditional upfront week entirely — moving its presentation all the way up to April 15. That's a statement about how the company sees the week itself. Under new ownership dynamics (Skydance closed, pending HBO IP), Paramount is leaning hardest on measurement and intimate dealmaking as its wedge.

HIGHLIGHTS

- CBS moved to April 15 — first major publisher to formally exit upfront week
- Skydance merger closed; HBO IP acquisition in motion from WBD
- iSpot 'Outcomes at Scale' deployment — attribution as the lead pitch
- UFC exclusive rights beginning 2026 — new tentpole for Paramount+
- Franchise slate: Yellowstone, Halo, Tracker, Ghosts, Daily Show, Colbert
- March Madness, NFL, UEFA, NWSL, PGA anchoring live

WATCH FOR

Ad Sales Chief John Halley's intimate-dinners format is the anti-upfront. Calendar move reinforces it — Paramount is betting on relationships over stagecraft.

PUBLISHER · 07

Netflix

"From skeptic to scale player."

UPFRONT:
UPFRONT · MAY 2026 · LOCATION TBA

AVOD LIVE FIRST-PARTY

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●●○
Sports Leverage	●●●○○
Streaming Scale	●●●●●
Audience Youth	●●●●●
Flexibility	●●●○○

Netflix doubled its upfront commitments for the 2025–26 season. Together with Amazon, it now accounts for ~30% of streaming ad sales. The ads tier has moved from experimental to central — and live (NFL Christmas, WWE Raw, boxing) is the acquisition wedge.

HIGHLIGHTS

- AVOD tier now a majority of new signups in many markets
- First-party signal finally operationalized for advertisers
- Live programming (NFL Christmas, WWE Raw, tentpole boxing) driving appointment viewing

WATCH FOR

Netflix's first-party data plus original IP may be the market's most under-priced combination.

PUBLISHER · 08

YouTube

"Already the biggest screen in the living room."

UPFRONT:
BRANDCAST · MAY 2026 · LINCOLN CENTER

CTV #1 SHORTS NFL SUNDAY TICKET

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●●●
Sports Leverage	●●●●○
Streaming Scale	●●●●●
Audience Youth	●●●●●
Flexibility	●●●●○

YouTube crossed every meaningful viewership threshold years ago; the 2026 upfront is about packaging. NFL Sunday Ticket, creator-led Shorts, and connected-TV reach position it as the platform that does not need to argue for its relevance.

HIGHLIGHTS

- #1 streaming platform by watch time on CTV (Nielsen Gauge)
- NFL Sunday Ticket deepening sports story
- Shorts monetization maturing; creator-as-channel scaling
- Full Google measurement stack as the unique selling point

WATCH FOR

YouTube is the platform the industry still under-weights in upfront conversations.

PUBLISHER · 09

Roku

"The neutral operating system."

UPFRONT:
NEWFRONTS · MAY 2026

OS SCALE
ROKU CHANNEL
ACR
UNIVERSAL ADS

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●●○
Sports Leverage	●●○○○
Streaming Scale	●●●●●
Audience Youth	●●●○○
Flexibility	●●●●●

Roku's role is structural: the operating system on tens of millions of primary-screen households, with ACR data that powers attribution nobody else can offer. Now also a Universal Ads partner with NBCU — deepening the SMB self-serve story.

HIGHLIGHTS

- The Roku Channel is a top-5 FAST destination
- ACR data uniquely cross-app, cross-publisher
- Universal Ads partnership with NBCU, WBD, LG Ad Solutions, Vizio — SMB democratization
- DSP partnerships deepening with Amazon DSP and The Trade Desk

WATCH FOR

Roku's value is as a measurement substrate and a buy-side gateway, not just a content destination.

PUBLISHER · 10

Telemundo

"Live TV is the mission. Multicultural scale is the proof."

UPFRONT:
TUE · MAY 12, 2026 · TRIBECA PERFORMING ARTS CENTER · CLIENT EXPERIENCE

LIGA MX
LIVE
MULTICULTURAL

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●○○
Sports Leverage	●●●●●
Streaming Scale	●●○○○
Audience Youth	●●●●○
Flexibility	●●●●○

"If you are live, you are on Telemundo." Luis Fernandez's positioning for 2026 is blunt and correct: 70%+ of the Telemundo lineup is live. Liga MX, Copa Oro, the Spanish-language Super Bowl LXI simulcast, and the widest multicultural live-sports slate in U.S. media anchor the year. The 2026 presentation is being framed as a "client experience" rather than a traditional upfront.

HIGHLIGHTS

- Exclusive Spanish-language Super Bowl LXI simulcast (Feb 2027)
- Liga MX + Copa Oro — the most-watched soccer properties in U.S. Spanish-language TV
- 70%+ of programming is live
- Client Experience format replacing the traditional showcase
- Multicultural + multigenerational family targeting

WATCH FOR

For brands chasing scaled multicultural live audiences, Telemundo is still the single most efficient buy. Expect premium pricing on Super Bowl LXI and Liga MX inventory.

PUBLISHER · 11

Apple TV+

"Prestige, quiet, expanding."

UPFRONT:
UPFRONT ENGAGEMENT 2026 TBA

MLS
F1
PRESTIGE

SCORECARD

AI / Measurement	●●●○○
Sports Leverage	●●●●○
Streaming Scale	●●●○○
Audience Youth	●●●○○
Flexibility	●●●○○

Apple has been the upfront's wild card — prestige originals, MLS Season Pass, an F1 presence, and a rumored ad-tier discussion that would reshape the streaming ad market if it actually lands in 2026.

HIGHLIGHTS

- MLS Season Pass — the template for league-exclusive streaming
- F1 rights adding live global appeal
- Ad-tier launch persistently rumored; if/when it lands, supply dynamics shift

WATCH FOR

A real Apple ad tier would be the single biggest supply event of 2026.

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE · EXXONMOBIL FUELS

12

The Category Is Traditional. That's The Opportunity.

The fuels category remains more traditional in its allocation approach than the broader market – heavy in National and Local TV, slower in CTV and measurement adoption. That's an opportunity: advanced video, agentic execution, and outcomes-based measurement are where advantage will be built in 2026.

SHELL

01

#1 FUELS-CATEGORY SPENDER · SEARCH-LED IN 2025

Linear TV ticked up slightly in 2025 but stayed minimal. Prioritized Search, held Digital/Social at ~25% of spend. Still cautious on CTV premium.

BP

02

NEAR-FULL LINEAR TV DIVESTMENT YOY 2024 → 2025

Pulled back sharply from Linear TV and also decreased Digital spend – consolidating investment into Search. Conservative CTV posture; no meaningful video footprint heading into 2026.

CHEVRON

03

$0 IN TV IN 2025 · DARK ON THE CATEGORY

Eliminated TV spend YoY from 2024 and shifted budget into Search and Digital/Social, with a dominant focus on fuels messaging. No linear or CTV footprint heading into 2026.

MARATHON

04

LINEAR-HEAVY, BUT DE-WEIGHTING

Linear TV dropped from 64% of spend in 2024 to 44% in 2025 – still a large commitment, anchored to Big Ten college football sponsorship. 2026 opened with a major campaign launch around their new 'Gascot' mascot.

THE OPENING

The category has bifurcated. Shell, BP, and Chevron have retreated from TV into Search and lower-funnel digital – trading brand-building for efficiency. Marathon is the outlier, still committing ~44% to linear behind Big Ten and the 'Gascot' launch. That leaves premium video wide open: outcomes-priced CTV sports inventory, measurement partnerships that prove lift, national-plus-local hybrid packages enabled by the new streaming bundles, and agentic execution on scatter – ExxonMobil can own the brand-building lane the rest of the category has abandoned, while Marathon plays the only other hand on the board.

THE UM TAKE · RECOMMENDATIONS + PREDICTIONS

13

How We'd Walk Into The Room.

Enough diagnosis. Here's where we'd put our chips – six recommendations for the 2026 buy, and seven predictions for what we think actually happens in the room. Sharpen your pencils.

SIX RECOMMENDATIONS

01

TREAT THE UPFRONT AS A FRAMEWORK, NOT A COMMITMENT

The most successful 2026 buys will be structured for optimization year-round – agentic execution, scatter flex, and programmatic roll-forward terms agreed to at the table.

02

PRICE AGAINST OUTCOMES, NOT IMPRESSIONS

Bring iSpot, VideoAmp, or partner clean-room measurement into every negotiation as a baseline expectation. Networks that resist are telling you something.

03

PAY THE PREMIUM FOR SPORTS AND LIVE

Live inventory is the only thing scaling against audience fragmentation. NFL, Super Bowl LXI, NBA Year 1, Ryder Cup, CFP – these are where sight-sound-motion reach still compounds.

04

LEAN INTO STREAMING BUNDLES, NOT INDIVIDUAL SERVICES

Disney+/Hulu/Max and the emerging Paramount-WBD bundle unlock cross-portfolio measurement. Negotiate at the bundle level, not the service level.

05

FOR FUELS SPECIFICALLY: LEAD THE CATEGORY ON CTV + MEASUREMENT

The rest of the category is cautious. The brand that moves first on outcomes-priced CTV at scale sets a narrative competitors will spend 2026 chasing.

06

INVEST IN INTERNAL AGENTIC LITERACY

UM planners should be operating ChatEDO, evaluating TTD Koa outputs, and understanding AdCP by end of Q2 2026. The agency-side moat is the taste to know when agent outputs are right.

SIX PREDICTIONS FOR THE 2026 ROOM

01	At least two more major publishers announce agentic-buying products at their Upfront presentations — following NBCU/FreeWheel's Q1 deal.	CONFIDENCE · HIGH
02	Apple quietly confirms an ad-supported tier inside a broader bundle announcement.	CONFIDENCE · MED
03	Netflix moves from 'premium scatter' posture to aggressive upfront volume commitments.	CONFIDENCE · HIGH
04	At least one network formally publishes outcomes-based CPM pricing tied to iSpot or VideoAmp.	CONFIDENCE · HIGH
05	A measurable scatter-over-upfront shift in two of the top-10 advertiser categories (likely Retail and Auto) as brands preserve optionality.	CONFIDENCE · MED
06	Super Bowl LXI on NBC/Peacock commands the highest :30 price in Super Bowl history, sold largely as measurement-linked packages rather than standalone spots.	CONFIDENCE · HIGH
07	By end of 2026, AdCP becomes the de-facto interoperability standard for agentic buying across at least 60% of major DSPs.	CONFIDENCE · MED

SIGNING OFF

READ BY MACHINES.
BOUGHT BY HUMANS.

The 2026 Upfront isn't about which screen wins. It's about which layer of decisioning you own – and whether your plan is built to be read by humans, machines, or both.

ABOUT THIS BRIEF

Full Stream Ahead is UM Worldwide's annual Upfronts POV, produced for ExxonMobil and the UM planning community. Vol. 02 covers the 2026 U.S. broadcast Upfronts, April–May 2026.

MASTHEAD

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